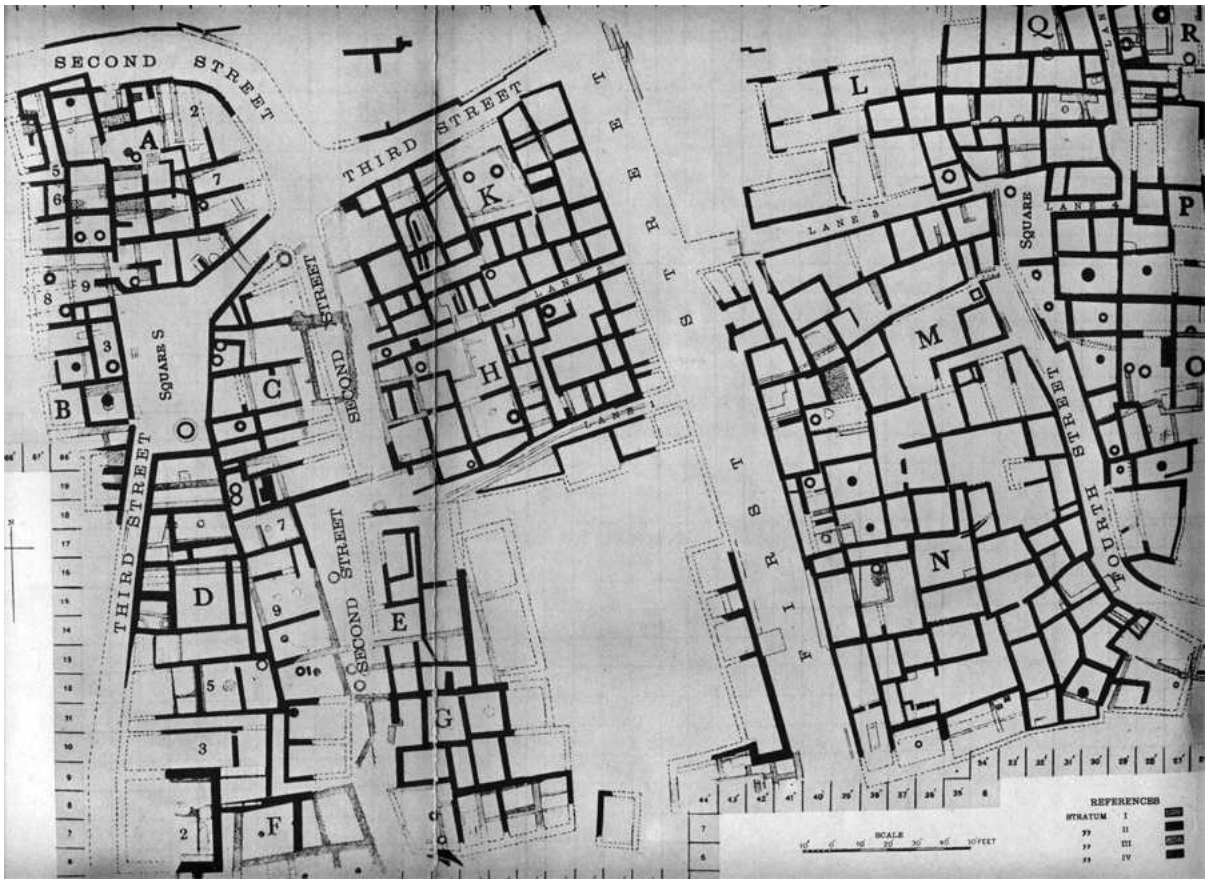


Fig. 3.1: The city plan of Mauryan Taxila on the Bhir mound

Taxila's geometry presents another contrast with the quality of planning that went into creating the system of drainage at Pataliputra, where we have already seen an impressive network of underground wooden drains. Taxila was also very different from the first cities of the north-west, such as Harappa and Mohenjodaro, that flourished in the third millennium BCE. Comparisons between cities separated by more than two millennia are not specially useful, but for the historian of archaeology it is difficult not to think of India's first cities in connection with Taxila since Marshall, who presided over the discovery of those first cities, also excavated Taxila. His report on Mohenjodaro describes streets that, like Taxila's First Street, run remarkably straight and most of them, he showed, had burnt-brick drains associated with them.[23]